Government Data APIs

Week 11 · APIs module · Textbook Chapter 11

Brian C. Keegan, Ph.D.
Associate Professor, Department of Information Science
University of Colorado Boulder

October 26, 28 & 30, 2026

This week at a glance

Two public APIs, each showing one idea that holds for every API. This week, every class is live coding, from one lab notebook in three parts.

Monday | Lab, part 1: the Census

- Keys, and *what can I ask for?* — the variable and geography catalogs

Wednesday | Lab, part 2: more of the Census

- Comparing places, margins of error, and the places the survey couldn't measure

Friday | Lab, part 3: FRED

- *Let the server compute*; then textbook revisions

The lab

`labs/week-11/lab-11.ipynb` in the course repository. Each part is added before its day.

Two keys, kept out of the notebook

`CENSUS_KEY` Monday and Wednesday; `FRED_KEY` Friday. Links are in the Canvas announcement and the lab's first cell.

Due Sunday, Nov 1

Chapter 11's **Recommended Exercises**, from its companion notebook. Graded on good-faith attempt to complete rather than getting everything working.

1. Monday · Live-Coding Lab

This week, every class is live coding

Find it | `labs/` in the course repository

1. Open the **labs** folder of `cuinfoscience/INF04617-Fall2026` on GitHub
2. Open `week-11`, click `lab-11.ipynb`, then **Download raw file**
3. Open it in JupyterLab in the `webdata` environment, *after* setting your keys

Use it | one part a day

- I write the code on screen, and you write it in your copy
- Put **your** email in the User-Agent in Step 0
- Today: Part 1, Steps 0–6, about 50 minutes
- Wednesday and Friday: download the new copy and start at that part's setup step

Solutions

`lab-11-key.ipynb`, beside it: every cell filled in and run. Fall behind? Copy the cell from the key and keep going.

Nothing to submit

The lab is practice. After each step, a **Discuss** box holds questions we'll talk over before the next.

Error flavors

A missing key stops Step 0 *on purpose*: set it and run again. A cell that fails with your key set is *broken*: tell me, or open an issue.

No key yet?

Follow along: the key shows every output. A Census key works only after you click the link in its email.

Public data by mandate

Government APIs exist because of democratic commitments to **transparency** — not business strategy:

- The **Census Bureau** is constitutionally mandated to count the population.
- The **Federal Reserve** publishes the economic data it collects; FRED is the St. Louis Fed's service for it.
- The **Energy Information Administration** was created in 1977, after the energy crises, to publish independent energy statistics.
- The **Library of Congress** publishes Congress's legislative record at Congress.gov.

They embody the **openness** value from Ch. 3, *The Post-API Age*: public data, freely accessible by mandate rather than platform goodwill.

Stable, but less polished

Agencies don't pivot business models or get acquired — so these APIs are unusually **stable**. The tradeoff: dense docs, cryptic variable names, unhelpful errors. Navigating that *is* the skill.

Two APIs, two ideas

Week 10's Wikipedia taught **pagination**. Each API this week teaches one more idea you'll meet in every API:

Day	API	The idea
Monday, Wednesday	Census Bureau	**Discovery**: ask the API what you can ask for
Friday	FRED	**Let the server compute**: transforms in the request
On your own	EIA	**Let the server filter**: facets narrow the data before it's sent
On your own	Congress.gov	**Follow the links**: records point to related records

And one idea across all of them: a **key** says who you are, and it stays out of your notebook.

Keys stay out of the notebook

A **key** identifies you, counts your requests, and enforces rate limits. A key typed into a notebook travels with it: into a commit, a submission, a classmate's laptop.

Store it with the `webdata` environment, once, in a terminal (on Windows, the Anaconda Prompt); then restart Jupyter and read it:

```
conda env config vars set CENSUS_KEY="your-key" -n webdata
```

```
import os
census_key = os.environ["CENSUS_KEY"] # a missing key stops here
```

The User-Agent still says who sent each request: `WebDataScience/1.0 (your-email@colorado.edu)`.

Or in your shell

`export CENSUS_KEY="your-key"` in `~/.zshrc` or `~/.bashrc`; `setx` on Windows. Chapter 11's "Setting Environment Variables" shows both ways.

Or a file

A JSON file, `api_keys.json`, added to `.gitignore` *before your first commit*. A key in git history stays there even after you delete the file.

Names

The lab uses `CENSUS_KEY` and `FRED_KEY`. Chapter 11 uses the same names, and `EIA_KEY` for the EIA.

Discovery: two catalogs before any data

What | the variable catalog

- Variables come in **groups**: `B25034` is "Year Structure Built"
- `B25034_002E`: group, line, and `E` for estimate (`M` is its margin of error)
- `.../acs5/groups/B25034.json` is itself an API

Where | the geography catalog

- `.../acs5/geography.json` lists every level the dataset answers for
- Each says what it **requires**: a `place` needs a `state`; a `tract` needs a `state` and a `county`
- Places are **FIPS codes**, as strings: Colorado `08`, Boulder `07850`

Codes change between survey years: learn to look them up, not to memorize them. Then **sanity-check** one value: Boulder's median household income is $87,493 (±$6,221), not 7 or 70 million.

Census — from the catalogs to a real place

Name the variables with `get`, the place with `for`, and what it requires with `in`:

```
census_base = "https://api.census.gov/data/2024/acs/acs5"
params = {"get": "NAME,B25034_001E,B25034_002E,B25034_003E",
          "for": "place:07850", # Boulder: a FIPS code, kept as a string
          "in": "state:08", # a place requires its state
          "key": census_key}
data = requests.get(census_base, params=params, headers=HEADERS).json()

df = pd.DataFrame(data[1:], columns=data[0]) # row 0 is the header
numeric_cols = [c for c in df.columns if c.startswith("B25034")]
df[numeric_cols] = df[numeric_cols].apply(pd.to_numeric) # values arrive as strings
```

Boulder has 47,465 housing units; 646 were built in 2020 or later, 3,836 in the 2010s.

2. Wednesday · Live-Coding Lab

Today: Part 2, more of the Census

We finish what Monday started, with the Census alone:

- **Compare** two cities in one request, and draw them
- Read a **margin of error** before saying two places differ
- Find the places the survey **couldn't measure**, before they wreck an average

Use it | Steps 4–7, about 33 minutes

- Download the new `lab-11.ipynb`; start at **Step 4**, which imports and checks the key again
- Put **your** email in the User-Agent

One key today

`CENSUS_KEY`. Still `MISSING`? The next three frames.

Friday

FRED, and *let the server compute*. Get `FRED_KEY` from a free FRED account before then.

On your own

The EIA and Congress.gov: Friday's last frames say where to start.

Treat an API key like a password

Never paste a key into a notebook cell or a code file

Whatever is in a cell is saved with the notebook, and goes wherever it goes: a commit, a submission, a screenshot, a classmate's laptop. There are three safe ways in; the first is the one to set up once.

1 | An environment variable, set before Jupyter starts

Any system: with the `webdata` environment

In a terminal (on Windows, the Anaconda Prompt):

```
conda env config vars set CENSUS_KEY="your-key" -n webdata
```

Then **close that terminal and open a new one**, and start Jupyter from it:

```
conda activate webdata
jupyter lab
```

Or in your shell

Mac: add `export CENSUS_KEY="your-key"` to `~/.zshrc` (Linux: `~/.bashrc`). **Windows:** `setx CENSUS_KEY "your-key"`.

Either way, **close the terminal, open a new one**, and start Jupyter from the new one. A terminal reads its settings only when it opens, and Jupyter reads its variables only when it starts: a Jupyter already running must be quit (**File → Shut Down**) and started again. Restarting the kernel isn't enough.

In the notebook: `census_key = os.environ["CENSUS_KEY"]`

Two more safe ways: a JSON file, or `getpass()`

2 | A JSON file beside the notebook

`api_keys.json`, in the notebook's folder, added to `.gitignore` **before your first commit**:

```
{"census": "your-key", "fred": "your-key"}
```

Then, in the notebook:

```
import json

with open("api_keys.json") as f:
    keys = json.load(f)
census_key = keys["census"]
```

Never share the file, or the folder it's in.

3 | `getpass()`, when you can't restart

Each setup step's given cell asks only if the key is missing, so **Run All** is safe:

```
from getpass import getpass
if not os.environ.get("CENSUS_KEY"):
    os.environ["CENSUS_KEY"] = getpass(
        "CENSUS_KEY isn't set. Paste it here: ")
```

1. Run it. A box opens under the cell (in VS Code, at the top of the window).
2. Paste your key and press **Enter**. Nothing shows, on purpose.
3. Run the next cell, which reads the key. It lasts until the kernel restarts.

Paste only into the box, never between the quotation marks.

`KeyError`: Python can't see the key

Each setup step checks before it reads, and never prints the key:

```
print("CENSUS_KEY:", "set" if "CENSUS_KEY" in os.environ
                   else "MISSING")
# CENSUS_KEY: set
```

Jupyter sees only the variables set **before it started**, in **the place it started from**. The chapter's "When a Key Says `MISSING`" lists the usual causes:

- Jupyter was already running, or started from somewhere else: Navigator (which, on a Mac, doesn't read `~/.zshrc`), another terminal, VS Code
- `!export` in a notebook cell: its shell closes at once, and the key is now in the notebook
- Windows has no `export`; `setx` reaches only prompts opened after it
- `conda env config vars set`, without activating the environment again
- A different name: `CENSUS_KEY`, not `census_key` or `CENSUS_API_KEY`

Stuck at `[*]`? `getpass()` is waiting: look for its box, paste, press Enter.

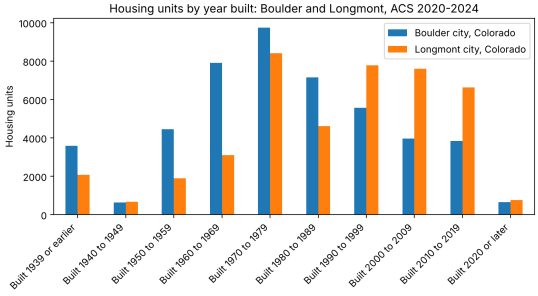
Two cities, ten decades

Step 5 puts two places in one request, asks for all ten decades of `B25034`, and labels them from Monday's catalog:

```
housing_vars = [f"B25034_{line:03d}E"
                for line in range(2, 12)]
params = {"get": "NAME," + ",".join(housing_vars),
          "for": "place:07850,45970",
          "in": "state:08", "key": census_key}

housing_catalog = requests.get(
    f"{census_base}/groups/B25034.json",
    headers=HEADERS).json()["variables"]
labels = {var: housing_catalog[var]["label"]
              .split("!!")[-1] for var in housing_vars}
```

Boulder's biggest decade was the 1970s; Longmont has more units from every decade since the 1990s.



Drawn by the chapter's code from the Census Bureau's API, 2026-10-25 (chapter 11, figure 11.4).

Microsprint

Counts don't compare cities of different sizes; shares do. Built in 2000 or later: Castle Rock 71%, Fort Collins 37%, Longmont 34%, Lakewood 18%, Boulder 18%.

Check a number against its margin

Each estimate has a margin of error, the same name ending in `M`, at 90% confidence. Step 6 asks for both:

```
params = {"get": "NAME,B19013_001E,B19013_001M",
          "for": "place:07850,45970",
          "in": "state:08", "key": census_key}
...
incomes["low"] = incomes["B19013_001E"] - incomes["B19013_001M"]
incomes["high"] = incomes["B19013_001E"] + incomes["B19013_001M"]
```

City	Estimate	Margin	Low	High
Boulder	87,493	6,221	81,272	93,714
Longmont	90,671	2,975	87,696	93,646

The ranges overlap

From \$87,696 to \$93,646, both are possible. The survey can't say which city's households earn more.

Discuss

Boulder's margin is twice Longmont's. What about the city could make its estimate less certain?

Which checks like this one could a pipeline run on its own, every time it runs?

When there's no estimate: `-666666666`

Step 7 asks for every place in Colorado, `for=place:*` with `in=state:08`, and looks before it trusts:

```
places["income"].describe().round()
# count 482.0
# mean -114723934.0
# min -666666666.0
# max 250001.0
```

83 of the 482 places have no median-income estimate: too few households answered. The API doesn't leave the value out; it sends a number that can't be an income. (250,001 is a cap: "$250,000 or more".)

Place	People	Median income
Boulder	106,433	87,493
Campo	58	53,125 (±40,478)
Bonanza	20	`-666666666`
Carbonate	0	`-666666666`

Average it as is

The mean of those four is −333,298,178. Mask the codes first, `towns.mask(towns < 0)`, and it's 70,309.

What the codes mean

The Census Bureau's notes on estimate and annotation values list each one; a margin of error of `-222222222` goes with it.

Discuss

Carbonate has no residents, yet it has a row. What does the Census count as a place?

3. Friday · Live-Coding Lab

Today: Part 3, FRED

Lab | Steps 8–13, about 35 minutes

- **FRED** (Federal Reserve Economic Data, from the St. Louis Fed) **computes** before it answers: changes, percent changes, yearly averages. Today's idea: *let the server compute*
- Boulder County's income, then inflation, then Denver against the nation
- Download the new `lab-11.ipynb`; start at **Step 8**, which sets up again

Then | the textbook, 15 minutes

- What the lab turned up in chapter 11, as a pull request

One key today

`FRED_KEY`, from a free FRED account. `MISSING`? Wednesday's three safe ways; `getpass()` works today.

Two parameter names

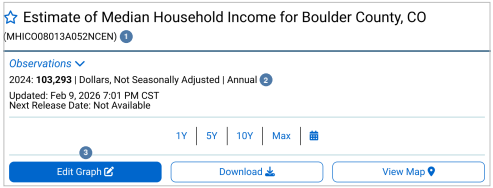
The Census Bureau calls its key parameter `key`; FRED calls it `api_key`.

FRED: find the series, then ask what it is

Every one of FRED's 800,000 series has an **ID** (1), on its page. The `series` endpoint describes it; `series/observations` sends its values:

```
fred_base = "https://api.stlouisfed.org/fred"
params = {"series_id": "MHICO08013A052NCEN",
          "api_key": fred_key, "file_type": "json",
          "observation_end": "2024-12-31"}
data = requests.get(f"{fred_base}/series/observations",
                    params=params, headers=HEADERS).json()
income = pd.DataFrame(data["observations"])[["date", "value"]]
income["value"] = pd.to_numeric(income["value"],
                                errors="coerce") # "." is missing
```

2024: $103,293 (2) — not the Census API's $103,994. Different programs: name the one you cite.



Boulder County's median household income on FRED, captured 2026-10-25 (chapter 11, figure 11.2).

Let the server compute: `units`

Step 10 gathers Step 9's lines into `fred_observations(series_id, **params)`. Then the *same series* twice more, one parameter changed:

```
change = fred_observations("MHICO08013A052NCEN",
           units="chg", observation_end="2024-12-31")
growth = fred_observations("MHICO08013A052NCEN",
           units="pch", observation_end="2024-12-31")
```

Year	Dollars	Change	Percent change
2022	96,584	6,257	6.9
2023	97,170	586	0.6
2024	103,293	6,123	6.3

What `units` can be

`lin`	as published
`chg`	change
`ch1`	change from a year before
`pch`	percent change
`pc1`	percent change from a year before
`log`	natural logarithm

Microsprint

In which years did the income *fall*? Six, from 2001 to 2020; the largest, $3,003 in 2009.

Let the server compute: `frequency`, then `units`

One series, `CPIAUCNS` (the national Consumer Price Index, monthly), three requests:

```
years = {"observation_start": "2015-01-01",
         "observation_end": "2025-12-31"}
monthly = fred_observations("CPIAUCNS", **years)
annual = fred_observations("CPIAUCNS", frequency="a",
           aggregation_method="avg", **years)
inflation = fred_observations("CPIAUCNS", frequency="a",
           aggregation_method="avg", units="pc1", **years)
```

FRED lowers the frequency first, then applies the units: each year's mean of twelve months, then its percent change from the year before.

Trust, but check once

Microsprint: the same numbers from `monthly`, with `groupby()` and `pct_change()`.

Year	FRED	pandas
2023	4.1	4.1
2024	2.9	2.9
2025	2.6	2.6

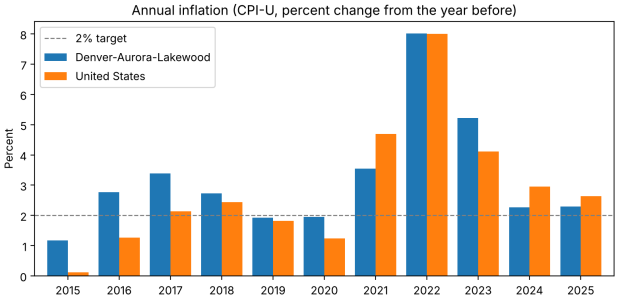
Why can FRED give 2015's inflation, and pandas can't?

Denver against the nation

The Bureau of Labor Statistics' CPI for the Denver area, `CUUSA433SA0`, is annual already: it needs only `units="pc1"`.

```
denver = fred_observations(
    "CUUSA433SA0", units="pc1", **years)
cpi = denver.merge(inflation, on="date",
    suffixes=("_denver", "_national"))
```

Denver ran ahead from 2015 to 2020, and behind since 2024. Housing is the largest part of the CPI: what would you ask FRED next?



Drawn by the chapter's code from FRED, 2026-10-25 (chapter 11, figure 11.5). The dashed line is the Federal Reserve's 2% target.

On your own: the EIA and Congress.gov

EIA | let the server filter

- The U.S. Energy Information Administration: prices, sales, and generation, by state, sector, and month
- Chapter 11's "EIA API v2": routes that describe themselves, facets that filter, paging with `offset`
- "Combining Census and EIA Data" joins Wednesday's incomes with the EIA's electricity bills, state by state
- Key: `EIA_KEY`, from the EIA by email

Congress.gov | follow the links

- The Library of Congress's bills, members, and votes: entry 8 of the chapter's "More Government APIs for Colorado"
- A bill's record links to its actions, cosponsors, and text; each link is a request you send as it is
- Key: from api.data.gov, sent in the `X-Api-Key` header



The EIA's API Dashboard, captured 2026-10-25 (chapter 11, figure 11.3): pick a data type (1) and facets (2), and it writes the request (3).

Friday: from the lab to the textbook (15 minutes)

Look back at what the lab turned up in chapter 11, and propose one change as a **pull request**:

- **A cell that broke.** On Monday, `os.environ["CENSUS_KEY"]` stopped with a `KeyError` for some of us. Does "When a Key Says `MISSING`" name your cause, and say clearly enough how to use `getpass()`?
- **A sentence that confused.** Which step needed the website beside the API to make sense? Does the chapter's tour do that for the Census table, and could it do more?
- **An output that has changed.** FRED revises some series. Compare Steps 11 and 12 with the chapter's.
- **A section the lab skipped.** Can you follow "EIA API v2" from the chapter alone?
- **A microsprint that would make a good exercise.** Searching `groups.json` for your own topic (Step 1), or two cities' margins (Step 6).

How to propose one

The course's `handouts/common/revision-framework.md` says what each kind of change needs to be accepted.

A good review

Run the change; name the line; separate "must fix" from "nice to have"; end with a verdict.

Key takeaways

1. Government APIs serve **public mandates**: the census, the Federal Reserve's data.
2. Each carried one idea you'll meet again: **ask what you can ask for** (Census), **let the server compute** (FRED).
3. **Start from the website**: find the number there, then ask the API for the same number, and check that they match.
4. **Read what isn't a number**: a margin of error, a code like `-666666666`, a cap at $250,000, a `"."` for missing.
5. **Treat keys like passwords**: an environment variable, a JSON file kept out of git, or `getpass()`; never in a cell or a code file, and never printed.